

Session 30: God Rests on the Seventh Day

Key Takeaways

- “Seven” (*sheva*) and “complete/full” (*sava*) are spelled with the same Hebrew consonants. Seven communicates a sense of fullness or completeness.
- There are two words used to describe God’s Sabbath rest on the seventh day of creation: *shabbat* (Gen. 2:2-3) and *nuakh* (Exod. 20:11). *Shabbat* means rest in the sense of stopping all work. *Nuakh* means rest in the sense of settling and taking up residence.
- When God completes his work and rests on the seventh day of creation, the authors are saying that God’s glorious presence fills the Earth. But he also takes up residence in creation with humanity—Heaven and Earth are truly united in this moment.

Time in Genesis 1 (Eschatology)

The most self-evident design feature of Genesis 1 is its seven-day sequence. The number seven is an organizing principle for the entire chapter from beginning to end.

The opening line of Genesis 1 has seven words, and the central word, untranslated in English, is two Hebrew letters, the first and last letters of the Hebrew alphabet.

7	6	5	4	3	2	1
הָאָרֶץ the land	וְ and	הַשָּׁמַיִם the skies	אֵלֶּף תַּב  	אֱלֹהִים God	בָּרָא he created	בְּרֵאשִׁית In-the-beginning
א = aleph / ת = tav						
Time in Genesis 1 (Eschatology). Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).						

Genesis 1:1 shows us that the structural design of sentences is meaningful and can convey deeper layers of significance. Here, the number seven is introduced as significant alongside the structural importance of the central word.

This same design structure is at work on the macro-level in Genesis 1: The first, middle, and final days all focus on the theme of time in a coordinated way.

See how the symmetrical emphasis on time in Genesis 1 and the literary design of day four (1:14-19) connect in the table below [adapted from Morales, Michael (2015). *Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?* 44.]. The narrative provides a foundation for all of Israel’s ritual calendar.

A: Time	B: Inhabitants	C: Time + Inhabitants	B': Inhabitants	A': Time
Day 1 Light and dark Day and night Daily Shema prayer Daily sacrifices in morning and evening Exodus 29:38-46	Day 2 Waters, sky dome Day 3 Dry land, plants	Day 4 Sun and moon Day and night Annual festivals Annual feast days and sacrifices Leviticus 23	Day 5 Fish, birds Day 6 Dry land, plants	Day 7 Sabbath day Jubilee cycle Sabbath ritual Jubilee year Leviticus 25-26
Design Emphasis on Time in Genesis 1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).				

A	1:14a And God said, "Let the lights be in the skies for dividing between the day and between the night ,		
	1:14b and let them be for signs and for festival times and for days and years.		
	B	1:15 And let them be for lights in the dome of the skies, to give light upon the land."	
		C	1:16a And God made the two great lamps, the great light for ruling over the day
		C'	1:16b and the little lamp for ruling over the night and also the stars.
	B	1:17 And he set them in the dome of the skies, to give light upon the land,	
A	1:18a and rule over the day and over the night		
	1:18b and to divide between the light and between the darkness.		
Design of Day Four. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).			

This design highlights the structural significance of divinely-ordered time in Genesis 1. God provides the essential order (day one) and then delegates the maintenance of that order to others (day four), which is mirrored by the sacred calendar of Israel. All of this looks forward to and leads up to the Sabbath (day seven).

Other Patterns of Seven in Genesis 1

In his book *A Commentary on the Book of Genesis*, biblical scholar Umberto Cassuto draws attention to patterns of seven in the first movement of Genesis.

- There are **seven words** in Genesis 1:1 and **fourteen words** in Genesis 1:2.
- There are **seven paragraphs** in Genesis 1:1-2:3 marked by “evening and morning.”
- The concluding **seventh paragraph** in Genesis 2:1-3 begins three lines which have **seven words** each (2:2-3a).

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
and-he-finished	God	one-the-day	the-seventh	his-work	which	he-made
and-he-ceased	on the day	the-seventh	from-all	his-work	which	he-made
and-he-blessed	God	the	day	the-seventh	and-he-sanctified	it

Patterns of Seven in Genesis 1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).

Each of the key words in Genesis 1:1 are repeated by multiples of **seven** in the opening movement of Genesis.

- “God” = 35x (7x5) in Genesis 1:1-2:3
- “Land” = 21x (7x3) in Genesis 1:1-2:3
- “Skies” and “dome” = 21x (7x3) in Genesis 1:2-2:3

Key words that are repeated **seven times**:

- “Light” (5x) and “day” (2x) = seven times on day one
- “Light” on day four
- “Living creature” (חיה) on days five and six
- “God saw that it was good”

God speaks 10 times in Genesis 1:1-2:3.

- Seven of those times are divine creative commands to the creation itself: “Let there be”
- Three of those times are divine initiatives toward humanity: “Let us make ‘adam,” “be fruitful and multiply,” “behold I have given to you”

“To suppose that all these appearances of the number seven are mere coincidence is not possible. This numerical symmetry is, as it were, the golden thread that binds together all the parts of the section.”

Why the Number Seven?

Seven was a symbolic number in Israelite culture and literature. It communicated a sense of fullness or completeness (שבע "seven" is spelled with the same consonants as the word שבע, meaning "complete/full"). This makes sense of the pervasive appearance of seven patterns in the Bible.

The Hebrew word "seven" is a homonym with the Hebrew words for "complete/full."

- "Seven" = Hebrew *sheva'* / שבע
- "Complete, full" = Hebrew *sava'* / שבע
- "Oath, promise" = Hebrew *savua'* / שבע

The origin of seven symbolizing completeness possibly originates in the lunar calendar of moon cycles. The biblical Hebrew word for "month" is the same as "new moon" (חדש), a period of time made up of 29.5 days/month, consisting of four 7.3-day cycles, making a complete cycle of time. For more on this see Maurice H. Farbridge's book *The Biblical and Semitic Symbolism Of Numbers* (Farbridge, 2010).

However, the Israelite Sabbath cycle is independent of the moon cycle, and Sabbaths do not coincide with the new moon. Rather, the seven-day cycle in Genesis 1 is portrayed as the ideal complete time sequence of creation. It stands outside of any natural cycle of time (sun, moon, stars).

Why Does God Rest on the Seventh Day?

God's rest involves a matrix of ideas connected with temples. God is taking up his rest within a sacred space by filling it with his divine presence.

Two Key "Rest" Words Associated with Sabbath, *Shabat* and *Nuakh*

When God rests on the seventh day, the text uses the word *shabbat*, which means "to stop."

Genesis 2:1-2 NASB*

¹ Thus the heavens and the earth were completed, and all their hosts. ² On the seventh day God completed his work which he had done, and he **rested** (Heb. *shabbat*) on the seventh day from all his work which he had done

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Shabat = "to cease from." God ceases from his work because "it is finished" (Gen. 2:1). Compare Joshua 5:12, "the manna ceased (*shabbat*) on that day."

By the time we get to Exodus, this same rest is associated with another word, *nuakh*, which means "to take up residence."

Exodus 20:11 NASB*

For in six days the LORD made the heavens and the earth, the sea and all that is in them, and **rested** (Heb. *nuakh*) on the seventh day, therefore the LORD blessed the **Sabbath** (Heb. *shabbat*) day and made it holy.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Both of these, *shabbat* and *nuakh*, become closely associated words in the Hebrew Bible used to evoke an image of God’s presence filling his temple and bringing peace.

God’s rest involves a matrix of ideas connected with temples. God is taking up his rest within a sacred space by filling it with his divine presence.

Exodus 10:14 NASB*

The locusts came up over the land of Egypt and rested in all the land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Deuteronomy 12:10 ESV*

When you cross the Jordan and live in the land which the LORD your God is giving you to inherit, and he gives you rest from all your enemies around you so that you live in security ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Samuel 7:1 Instructor's Translation

Now when King David dwelt in his house, for Yahweh had provided rest from his enemies ...

In conclusion, when God or people *nuakh*, it always involves settling into a place that is safe, secure, and stable.

Creation is depicted as the cosmic prototype in Genesis 1. All later temples are symbolic miniatures of this prototype. In each later biblical temple, God’s presence fills the sacred space on the seventh day.

Creation and Sabbath	Tabernacle Designs and Sabbath	Tabernacle Completion and Sabbath	Jerusalem Temple Completion
Creation’s Completion (Gen. 1:31-2:3)	Tabernacle Instructions (Exod. 25-31)	Completion of the Tabernacle (Exod. 39-40)	1 Kings 6-8
Seven days open with divine command: “And God said ...” Day 1 — Gen. 1:5 Day 2 — Gen. 1:8	Seven speeches open with divine command: “And Yahweh spoke to Moses ...” Speech 1 — Exod. 25:1 Speech 2 — Exod. 30:11	Seven acts of obedience to the divine command complete tabernacle: “And Moses did ... just as Yahweh	Seven petitions of Solomon upon the completion of the temple: “Blessed be Yahweh who spoke to my father David.”
Cosmic Prototype of Creation and The Tabernacle and Temple as Symbolic Miniatures. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).			

Creation and Sabbath	Tabernacle Designs and Sabbath	Tabernacle Completion and Sabbath	Jerusalem Temple Completion
Day 3 — Gen. 1:13 Day 4 — Gen. 1:19 Day 5 — Gen. 1:23 Day 6 — Gen. 1:31 Day 7 — Gen. 2:1-3 Sabbath	Speech 3 — Exod. 30:17 Speech 4 — Exod. 30:22 Speech 5 — Exod. 30:34 Speech 6 — Exod. 31:1 Speech 7 — Exod. 31:12 Sabbath	commanded Moses.” Act 1 — Exod. 40:19 Act 2 — Exod. 40:21 Act 3 — Exod. 40:23 Act 4 — Exod. 40:25 Act 5 — Exod. 40:27 Act 6 — Exod. 40:29 Act 7 — Exod. 40:32-35 Divine rest	Petition 1 — 1 Kgs. 8:31-32 Petition 2 — 1 Kgs. 8:33-34 Petition 3 — 1 Kgs. 8:35-37a Petition 4 — 1 Kgs. 8:37b-40 Petition 5 — 1 Kgs. 8:41-43 Petition 6 — 1 Kgs. 8:44-45 Petition 7 — 1 Kgs. 8:46-53 Seven-day feasts
Seventh day culminates in Sabbath (Gen. 2:1-3)	Seventh speech emphasizes the “sign of Sabbath” (Exod. 31:12-17) Priesthood installed after a seven-day ordination (Exod. 28-29)	Seventh act of obedience “completes” the tabernacle	Solomon observes two seven-day feasts to dedicate the temple (1 Kgs. 8:65)
“And God saw all that he had done, and behold, it was very good. And there was evening and morning, the sixth day.” (Gen. 1:31) “And God blessed the seventh day.” (Gen 2:3)		“And Moses saw all the work they had done, and behold, just as Yahweh commanded, so they did, and Moses blessed them.” (Exod. 39:43)	“Then the king faced about and blessed all the assembly of Israel, while all the assembly of Israel was standing.” (1 Kgs. 8:14)
“and the skies and the land were completed (כלה)” (Gen. 2:1)	“and it came about when he completed (כלה) speaking to Moses	“and Moses completed (כלה) the work (מלאכה)” (Exod. 40:33)	“and Solomon built the temple and he finished (כלה) it” (1 Kgs. 6:14)
<i>Cosmic Prototype of Creation and The Tabernacle and Temple as Symbolic Miniatures. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).</i>			

Creation and Sabbath	Tabernacle Designs and Sabbath	Tabernacle Completion and Sabbath	Jerusalem Temple Completion
	on Mount Sinai" (Exod. 31:18)		
"and God rested (שבת) on the seventh day ..."		"and the cloud covered the tent of meeting, and the glory of Yahweh filled the tent" (Exod. 40:34)	"and the cloud filled the house of Yahweh" (1 Kgs. 8:10-11)
"... from all his work (מלאכה) ... and God blessed (ברך) the seventh day and made it holy (קדש)" (Gen. 2:2-3)	"you shall keep the Sabbath for it is holy (קדש) for you ... Six days let the work (מלאכה) be done, and on the seventh day it is a Sabbath of Sabbath." (Exod. 31:14-15)	Aaron and his sons are brought before the tent for seven days in the ordination ceremony (Lev. 8-9, see 8:35)	"In the eleventh year, in the ... eighth month, the temple was finished throughout all its parts and according to all its plans. So he was seven years in building it. (1 Kgs. 6:38) "And the work (מלאכה) of the pillars was finished." (1 Kgs. 7:22) "Thus all the work (מלאכה) that King Solomon performed in the house of the Lord was finished." (1 Kgs. 7:51)
Temptation and fall narrative: Genesis 3	Temptation and fall narrative: Exodus 32	Temptation and fall narrative: Leviticus 10	Temptation and fall narrative: 1 Kings 9:1-9 and 11:1-3
Cosmic Prototype of Creation and The Tabernacle and Temple as Symbolic Miniatures. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).			

In a Similar Way, the Temple in Israel Was Spoken of as the Place of God's Rest

Psalms 132:7-8, 13-14 NASB*

⁷ Let us go into his dwelling place/tent (Heb. *mishkan* / מִשְׁכָּן);
let us worship at his footstool.

⁸ Arise, O LORD, to your resting place (Heb. *menukhah* / מְנוּחָה),
you and the ark of your strength.

¹³ For the LORD has chosen Zion;
he has desired it for his habitation.

¹⁴ “This is my resting place (Heb. *menukhah* / מְנוּחָה) forever;
here I will sit enthroned, for I have desired it.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Exodus 15:17-18 NASB*

¹⁷ “You will bring them and plant them in the mountain of your inheritance,
the place, O LORD, which you have made for your dwelling (Heb. *le-shibteka* / *shabbat* / לִשְׁבֹּתְךָ),
the sanctuary, O LORD, which your hands have established.

¹⁸ The LORD shall reign forever and ever.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“The role of the temple in ancient Israel was not only a place where people gathered for worship. It is first and foremost a place for the deity—sacred space. It is God’s home, but more importantly, his headquarters—the control room. When the deity rests in his temple, it means that he is taking command, that he is mounting his throne to assume his rightful place and his proper role. ... So, what did God do on the eighth day? In this view, on the eighth day, and every day since then, he is in the control room from where he runs the cosmos that he set up. This is the ongoing work of creation. If one thinks of Genesis 1 as an account of material origins, God’s creating is an action in the past that is now over and done with. God made the physical universe and now the cosmos exists. But viewing Genesis 1 as an ancient account of the cosmos’ functional origins offers a more faithful account to the scriptural depiction of God’s creational ‘rest’ as ongoing.”

Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2–3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic. 75, 77.

“Humanity’s elevation, made in the image of God, is designed for the exaltation of the Sabbath day. The Sabbath thus becomes the day for humanity to enjoy its privileged status of being created as God’s image. The Sabbath is the symbolic time for humanity’s climactic union with and representation of its Creator. ... Just as the divine work began with a workman’s week as an archetype of the human week, now humanity can live in the image of God. The Sabbath and the image of God are linked together and interdependent themes.”

Morales, Michael (2015). [*Who Shall Ascend the Mountain of the Lord?: A Biblical Theology of the Book of Leviticus*](#). IVP Academic. 48.

Why Does God Bless the Seventh Day?

God’s blessing upon the creatures and humans on days five and six is directly tied to being fruitful and multiplying and filling the land.

By analogy, the blessing on the Sabbath would also involve a kind of fruitfulness, multiplying, and filling that is appropriate to a period of time. The idea is that the Sabbath would become many as it is observed and experienced by others.

“Set apart from all other days, the blessing of the seventh day establishes the seventh part of created time as a day when God grants his presence in the created world. It is then his presence that provides the blessing and the sanctification. The seventh day is blessed and established as the part of time that assures fruitfulness, future-orientation, continuity, and permanence for every aspect of life within the dimension of time. The seventh day is blessed by God’s presence for the sake of the created world, for all nature, and for all living beings.”

Frey, Mathilde (2011). [*The Sabbath in the Pentateuch: an Exegetical and Theological Study*](#). Andrews University Digital Commons. 38.

The Seventh Day That Has No End

The seven days portray God working to bring order and life out of darkness and chaos. This divine work culminates in the delegation of human images who rule the fruitful land on God’s behalf (day six). Creation is “completed” (Gen. 2:1) only after God delivers creation from the darkness and chaos waters and appoints a human image to rule. After he completes creation, God can rest/cease from his work.

“Unlike the previous days, the seventh day is simply announced. There is no mention of evening or morning, no mention of a beginning or ending. The suggestion is that the primordial seventh day exists in perpetuity, a sacred day that cannot be abrogated by the limitations common to the rest of the created order.”

Balentine, Samuel (1999). [*The Torah’s Vision of Worship*](#). Fortress Press. 93.

“The seventh-day account does not end with the expected formula, ‘there was evening and morning,’ that concluded days one through six. Breaking the pattern in this way emphasizes the uniqueness of the seventh day and opens the door to an eschatological interpretation. Literarily, the sun has not yet set on God’s Sabbath.”

Lowry, Richard (2000). [*Sabbath and Jubilee*](#). Chalice Press. 90.

“The Sabbath is that point in time where God and man meet. On the seventh day of creation, God joined himself and his eternal presence to his temporal creation, to the world of man. On the Sabbath day, man not only recalls but participates in an act of cosmic creation ... he experiences the original structuring of time within the microcosm of his own life. ... The observance of the Sabbath links humanity to a divinely ordained future, as well as a divinely created past. Sabbath observance has cosmic implications ... a foretaste of an eschatological future ... a prefiguration of the final phase of the divine/human reconciliation. In pointing back to the beginning, the Sabbath also points to what is yet to be, to the final destiny to which all creation is moving.”

Och, Bernard (1995). “Creation and Redemption: Towards a Theology of Creation.” *Judaism: A Quarterly Journal of Jewish Life and Thought*. Volume 44 (No. 2). 240.

“With regard to the lack of the final formula, 'there was evening and there was morning,' commentators have argued that the seventh day is not meant to be understood as a literal day. This argumentation then has led to an eschatological interpretation of the seventh day. However, as part of the first creation account, the seventh day is the last of the seven sections, and the formula 'there was evening and there was morning' in the account of the weekdays may be taken not only as a closing formula but also as a literary feature to anticipate what comes next within the series of sections in the creation account, that is the next day of the creation week. Functioning as a transition from one day to another the closing formula is a feature that moves the text forward throughout the six weekdays with the intention to arrive at the seventh day. Once it arrives at the last section, the text highlights the identification of the seventh day by stating it three times and then has no more need for the formula because there is no eighth section following for an eighth day. Creation has come to an end, for the seventh day has arrived.”

Frey, Mathilde (2011). [The Sabbath in the Pentateuch: an Exegetical and Theological Study](#). Andrews University Digital Commons. 38.

Israel’s Sacred Calendar in Leviticus 23

In Leviticus, the Sabbath ideal is multiplied by seven. [Leviticus 23](#) lists seven meeting/convocation days for Israel’s holy worship. Every one (except firstfruits) is a multiple of seven (in days or the month) or a duration of seven and represents a moment of new creation.

Holy Day		Date	Duration	Activity	Ritual Story
1	Sabbath	7th day	1 day	No work	Creation and rest
First Half of the Year					
2	Passover and Unleavened Bread	1/14 1/15-21	1 day + 7 days	No work on 1st and 7th day	Exodus liberation into the promised land
3	Firstfruits	Day after 7th day	1 day	—	Celebrating the gift of food
4	Weeks/Pentecost	7 x 7 + 1 days after Sabbath	1 day	No work	Celebrating the gift of food
Second Half of the Year					
5	Trumpets	7th month / 1st day	1 day	No work	Marking the 7th month
Israel’s Sacred Calendar in Leviticus Chapter 23. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).					

Holy Day		Date	Duration	Activity	Ritual Story
6	Day of Atonement	7th month / 10th day	1 day	No work	Removing sin and death from the camp
7	Tabernacles	7th month 7/15-7/21	7 days	No work on 1st and 7th day	Provision in the midst of the wilderness
<i>Israel's Sacred Calendar in Leviticus Chapter 23. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).</i>					

The principle of the Sabbath (a burst of Eden rest into ordinary time) is here multiplied by seven. All these holy days participate and develop some aspect of meaning of the original Sabbath.

- Passover and Unleavened Bread celebrate redemption from death (new creation) and commitment to simplicity and trust in God's power to provide food in the wilderness.
- Firstfruits and Weeks celebrate the gift of produce from the land.
- Trumpets announces the sabbatical (seventh) month.
- Day of Atonement celebrates God's renewal of the holiness of his Eden presence among his compromised people.
- Tabernacles celebrates provision for God's people on their way to the promised land/Eden. They are to live in God's "tent" for a Sabbath cycle. Leviticus 23:40 says, "And you will take the fruit of the beautiful tree, the branches of a palm, and branches of a tree of leaf and of poplar trees by a river, and you shall rejoice before Yahweh for seven days." This is a mini-Eden tent made of the fruit of a beautiful tree for a Sabbath cycle (Gen. 1-2)!

Reflection Question

What is the significance of God resting on the seventh day of creation?